

FOR MORE THAN THREE DECADES, DAYANITA Singh has built an artistic practice in which photographs rarely stand alone. Books become museums, exhibitions evolve into living archives, and images are constantly rearranged to create new conversations. With ARCHIVIO, presented at the Archivio di Stato di Venezia, she brings this philosophy into one of Italy's most significant repositories of historical memory.

The exhibition marks a historic first for the Venetian institution. Never before has the Archivio di Stato opened its doors as an exhibition venue. Curated by artist and designer Andrea Anastasio, ARCHIVIO asks visitors to rethink what an archive can be.

For Singh, the project begins with people. "What has remained constant," she says of her 25-year relationship with Italy, "is the friendship of the people you meet and the way they open their homes and hearts to you. It's actually very similar to how it is in India".

That spirit runs throughout ARCHIVIO. Over 350 photographs are arranged across 15 modular wooden structures that function as display, storage and sculpture. The structures can be reconfigured, allowing photographs to form new relationships with one another. Singh says she created the pillars because she "wanted photography to leave the wall", encouraging visitors to move around the work and discover new connections between images. "I've realised that the exhibition itself is the artwork," Singh explains. "The photographs are part of it. The structures are part of it. But the exhibition, in its entirety, is the work."

The exhibition combines photographs made across Italy since the late 1990s with Singh's studies of archives in Italy and India, bringing together images of museums, archives, homes, workshops and everyday interiors. The project itself grew from a chance visit to the Corsini Archive in Florence in 2001. "That was the first time in my life that I had seen the inside of an archive," Singh recalls. "My jaw simply dropped. I never imagined then that I would one day photograph inside archives."

Years later, friendships that opened homes, archives and private collections across Italy inspired the exhibition's Patrons Pillar. "When it came to making the exhibition, I began asking myself: who is really the patron? That's when I decided to create the Patrons Pillar. It honours all the people who opened their homes to me." For Anastasio, these relationships define the exhibition. He describes Singh's Italian archive as "a relational cartography". The photographs chart Italy through networks of friendship, hospitality and artistic exchange, revealing a country understood through human connection rather than monuments alone.

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Presenting this work inside the Archivio di Stato creates a dialogue between two ideas of the archive. While the institution preserves documentary memory, Singh's archive preserves something less tangible. "It does not preserve certainty," Anastasio says. "It preserves relationships." That philosophy also shapes the photographs themselves. "I never open the documents," Singh explains. "I'm not trying to tell people, 'Look, this is Napoleon', or 'This is Mussolini's hair'." Instead, she photographs what she calls the *mahaul*, or atmosphere, of the archive. "The question for me is whether it's possible to photograph that feeling."

For Singh, archives are also a tribute to the people